

Great thinkers

Throughout history, people have asked questions about the world and our place in it. Some great philosophers have come up with answers that have transformed our thinking – and others challenge us by posing new problems for us to think about.

► c.624–546 BCE

THALES “THE WISE”

Thales lived in Asia Minor (modern Turkey). He had the idea that water was the basic ingredient of everything, and that our world floated like a log in a universe of water.



► c.570–495 BCE

PYTHAGORAS

A Greek scientist, Pythagoras believed that everything in the universe could be explained by mathematics. He led a group of followers who obeyed his strict code about how to live, work, and honour the gods.

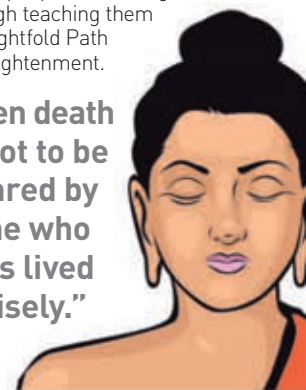


► c.563–483 BCE

SIDDHARTHA GAUTAMA

Known as the Buddha, or “enlightened one”, he taught that nothing in the world is permanent. His goal was to end people’s suffering, through teaching them the Eightfold Path to enlightenment.

“Even death is not to be feared by one who has lived wisely.”

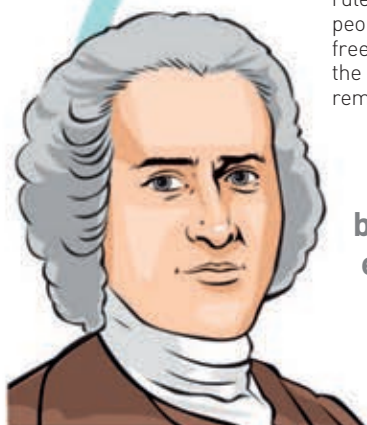


◀ 1712–78

JEAN-JACQUES ROUSSEAU

Rousseau said government is a contract between people and their rulers. If rulers ignore people’s rights and freedoms, they break the contract and can be removed from power.

“Man was born free but everywhere he is in chains.”



◀ 1711–76



DAVID HUME

Hume was a founder of “sceptical” philosophy, saying that there is nothing we can know for certain. He believed knowledge came only from direct experience, not from a person’s ideas or religious beliefs.

◀ 1694–1778

VOLTAIRE

A French poet, playwright, and historian, Voltaire argued for free speech – that in a civilized society, everybody should have the right to say and think whatever they like.



◀ 1632–1704

JOHN LOCKE

Englishman Locke believed that people have the right to control their own body, and no one can tell them what to do with it. His ideas about power and freedom influenced lawmakers in the newly formed USA, who based the American Constitution of 1787 in part on Locke’s ideas.

“Where there is no law, there is no freedom.”

◀ 1596–1650

RENE DESCARTES

Descartes started a revolution in philosophy by doubting everything – including whether he really existed. He decided that as he had thoughts, someone must be thinking them – so he must really exist.

“I think, therefore I am.”

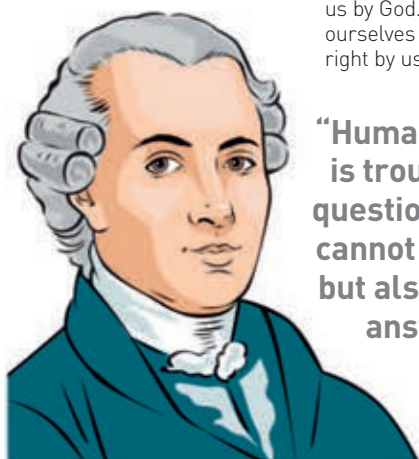


► 1724–1804

IMMANUEL KANT

Unlike many philosophers of his time, Kant believed that knowledge of what is right and wrong is not born in us or given to us by God. We decide for ourselves what is morally right by using reason.

“Human reason is troubled by questions that it cannot dismiss, but also cannot answer.”



► 1759–97

MARY WOLLSTONECRAFT

An English writer and teacher, she campaigned for women to have the same opportunities and rights as men. Her book, *A Vindication of the Rights of Women*, argued that girls should be educated as well as boys.



► 1806–73



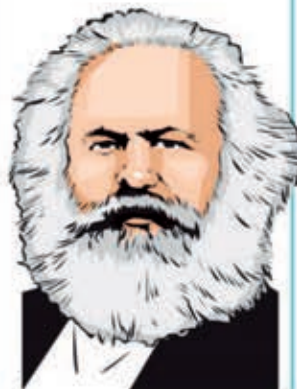
JOHN STUART MILL

English economist and political thinker who believed that all people should be free to do whatever they choose, so long as it does not harm other people, or prevent them from doing what they want.

► 1818–83

KARL MARX

A revolutionary economist and thinker, Marx founded the theory of socialism, in which all the property, resources, and wealth of a country is owned by the public, and not by individual people.



► 1844–1900

FRIEDRICH NIETZSCHE

A German writer whose main philosophy was that people should aim to achieve their full potential and be a “Superman” rather than an ordinary person.

